

“Addiction Control Features for Instagram Reels”

Title:

Product Case Study: Reels Addiction Control Features for Instagram

Problem Statement:

Excessive consumption of short-form video content on Reels has become a significant concern, particularly among students and young adults. Users often spend several hours continuously scrolling due to highly personalized content and infinite feed design. This behavior negatively impacts productivity, academic performance, sleep quality, and mental well-being. Despite awareness of overuse, many users struggle to regulate their behavior due to the lack of built-in control mechanisms. Therefore, there is a need for digital well-being features that help users manage their time effectively without eliminating the entertainment value of the platform.

Target Users:

Primary target users are:

- Teenagers and college students (13–25 years)
- Individuals with high daily screen time
- Users reporting productivity loss due to Reels usage
- Late-night users affected by sleep disruption

Secondary users include parents who want to monitor children's usage.

User Observation — Instagram Reels Usage

1. Why did I open Reels?

I usually open Reels for relaxation, entertainment, and to refresh my mind during free time.

2. How long did I stay?

On average, I spend about **3 hours per day** watching Reels.

3. What made me continue watching?

The videos are highly personalized to my interests such as travel, automobiles, technology,

animals, and devotional content.

The continuous scrolling and engaging short videos make it difficult to stop.

4. Did I try to stop? Why or why not?

I did not actively try to stop because the content is enjoyable and there is no natural stopping point.

5. How did I feel afterward?

I often feel guilty, especially when I have important work or exam preparation to do. Despite knowing I should study, I continue watching Reels for long periods without realizing how much time has passed.

User Research / Survey:

Number of Participants

A total of 5 respondents participated in the survey.

Due to time constraints, a small exploratory sample was used to identify initial behavioral patterns. Future studies can include larger populations for more generalizable insights.

Method Used:

The research was conducted using an online questionnaire created through Google Forms. The survey link was shared with students aged 17–25 to collect data on Reels usage behavior, impact, and control preferences.

Key Findings:

1. High Daily Usage:

1. Most respondents spend 3–5 hours per day on Reels
2. One respondent reported more than 5 hours daily
3. This indicates excessive engagement.

2. Frequent Usage During Free Time or Boredom:

1. Primary reasons for use:
2. Boredom
3. Entertainment
4. Stress relief

Reels is commonly used as a quick escape from routine tasks.

3. Difficulty Stopping:

Main reasons identified:

1. Habit formation
2. Infinite scrolling design
3. Lack of alternative activities

Continuous content flow makes disengagement difficult.

4. Negative Impact on Productivity:

Most participants reported that Reels usage affects:

1. Studies
2. Work performance
3. Daily routine

5. Negative Emotional Response:

Most users reported feeling **guilty after long usage**, indicating awareness of excessive consumption.

6. Attempts to Reduce Usage Were Mostly Unsuccessful:

1. Several respondents tried to reduce usage but failed
2. Only a few reported successful reduction

Shows need for built-in control tools.

7. Strong Demand for Control Features:

Suggested helpful features:

1. Time limit settings
2. Focus mode
3. Auto-lock after certain time

Indicates user readiness for addiction-control solutions.

User Insights:

Analysis of survey responses revealed several key behavioral patterns and problems associated with Reels usage.

1. Excessive Daily Usage

Most participants reported spending **3–5 hours per day**, with some exceeding 5 hours.

This indicates high engagement beyond normal entertainment use.

2. Difficulty in Stopping Usage

Participants identified several reasons for continued scrolling:

- Habit formation

- Infinite scrolling design
- Lack of alternative activities
- Highly engaging content

Reels encourages prolonged sessions without natural stopping points.

3. Negative Impact on Productivity

Most respondents reported that Reels usage affects:

- Studies
- Work
- Daily routine

4. Feelings of Guilt After Usage:

A majority of participants reported feeling **guilty after long sessions**, indicating awareness of excessive consumption.

Suggests distraction and reduced efficiency.

5. Failed Attempts to Reduce Usage:

Many respondents reported trying to reduce usage but being unsuccessful.

This shows lack of effective self-control tools.

6. Usage Driven by Boredom and Stress Relief:

Reels is primarily used as a coping mechanism for boredom, entertainment, or stress avoidance.

7. Strong Need for Control Features:

Participants indicated that tools such as:

- Time limits
- Focus mode
- Auto-lock features

would help reduce usage.

The proposed features are designed as optional and user-controlled tools so that individuals can choose the level of restriction that best suits their needs. This approach ensures flexibility, maintains user autonomy, and prevents negative impact on overall user experience while still addressing excessive usage.

Proposed Solutions:

Based on the identified user problems such as excessive usage, difficulty stopping, productivity loss, and feelings of guilt, a set of addiction-control features is proposed for Reels.

The goal is to help users manage their time effectively while still allowing them to enjoy content. The proposed system focuses on awareness, gentle reminders, and optional restrictions rather than forced limitations.

1. Smart Time Limit:

Users can set a daily limit for Reels usage.

After reaching the limit:

- A notification is displayed
- The user is encouraged to stop
- Option to extend usage (optional)

Helps reduce excessive time consumption

2. Focus Mode:

Allows users to block Reels during selected hours such as:

- Study time
- Work hours
- Important tasks

Reduces distractions and improves productivity.

3. Break Reminder:

After continuous scrolling (e.g., 20–30 minutes), the app shows a reminder:

You've been watching for a while. Take a short break.

Encourages mindful usage.

4. Auto-Lock After Limit:

If the user continues beyond the set limit, Reels can automatically lock for a defined period.

Prevents prolonged sessions caused by habit.

5. Sleep Protection Mode:

Restricts Reels usage during late-night hours.

Example:

"It's late. Continued scrolling may affect sleep."

Helps maintain healthy sleep patterns

6. Usage Dashboard:

Provides detailed statistics such as:

- Daily time spent
- Weekly trends

- Peak usage hours

Increases awareness of personal habits.

Title for Diagram: Feature Workflow (Addiction Control System):

User Opens Reels



Usage Tracking Active



Time Limit Reached?

YES → Show Reminder



Continue Watching?

YES → Auto-Lock

NO → Exit Reels



Usage Dashboard Updated

Key Features:

1. Smart Time Limit

This feature allows users to set a daily usage limit for Reels based on their personal preference.

Once the limit is reached, the application displays a notification reminding the user that their daily quota has been completed. Users may choose to stop or extend usage temporarily.

Purpose:

To reduce excessive screen time and promote disciplined usage.

Problem Solved:

Users spending more time than intended.

2. Focus Mode:

Focus Mode enables users to block access to Reels during selected hours such as study time, work hours, or important activities.

During this period, Reels content will not be accessible unless the user manually disables the mode.

Purpose:

To minimize distractions during productive periods.

Problem Solved:

Reduced concentration on studies or work.

3. Break Reminder:

This feature monitors continuous scrolling and sends a gentle reminder after a fixed duration (e.g., 20–30 minutes).

The message encourages users to pause, rest, or engage in other activities.

Purpose:

To promote mindful usage and prevent prolonged sessions.

Problem Solved:

Difficulty in stopping once started.

4. Auto-Lock After Limit:

If the user continues watching beyond the set time limit, this feature automatically locks Reels for a predetermined duration.

An option to unlock may be provided but requires deliberate action, reducing impulsive continuation.

Purpose:

To enforce stronger control for users who struggle with self-regulation.

Problem Solved:

Habit-driven excessive usage.

5. Sleep Protection Mode:

Sleep Protection Mode restricts Reels usage during late-night hours. When activated, the app displays warnings about potential sleep disruption and may limit access.

Purpose:

To encourage healthy sleep habits.

Problem Solved:

Late-night scrolling and sleep loss.

6. Usage Dashboard:

This feature provides a detailed summary of Reels activity, including:

- Daily time spent
- Weekly usage trends
- Peak usage hours

The dashboard helps users understand their behavior and track improvements over time.

Purpose:

To increase self-awareness and accountability.

Problem Solved:

Users unaware of how much time they spend.

Business Impact:

Implementing addiction-control features for Reels can provide significant long-term benefits to Meta Platforms, even if short-term engagement slightly decreases.

1. Improved Brand Image

By prioritizing user well-being, the company demonstrates social responsibility and ethical design practices. This enhances public perception and strengthens brand reputation.

2. Increased User Trust

Providing tools that help users manage screen time builds trust. Users are more likely to continue using the platform when they feel the company cares about their health and productivity.

3. Long-Term User Retention

Healthy usage patterns reduce burnout and fatigue. Users who feel in control of their time are more likely to remain active on the platform over the long term.

4. Reduced Regulatory Pressure

Governments and organizations worldwide are increasingly concerned about digital addiction. Implementing well-being features proactively can reduce the risk of regulations or restrictions.

5. Expanded User Base

Features such as parental controls and time limits make the platform safer for younger users, encouraging adoption by families and educational communities.

6. Competitive Advantage

Promoting digital well-being can differentiate the platform from competitors and position it as a responsible technology provider.

7. Data-Driven Product Improvement

Usage insights from control features can help the company better understand user behavior and refine future product strategies.

Success Metrics:

The effectiveness of the proposed addiction-control features can be evaluated using quantitative and qualitative metrics.

1. Reduction in Average Daily Usage

Measure the change in average time spent on Reels before and after enabling control features.

Lower excessive usage indicates success.

2. Feature Adoption Rate

Track the percentage of users who activate tools such as:

- Time limits
- Focus mode
- Break reminders

High adoption shows users find the features valuable.

3. Decrease in Continuous Viewing Sessions

Monitor the reduction in long, uninterrupted scrolling sessions.

Indicates improved self-control and mindful usage.

4. Reduction in Late-Night Usage

Analyze usage patterns during late hours to determine whether Sleep Protection Mode reduces nighttime activity.

5. Improvement in User Satisfaction

Collect feedback through in-app surveys to measure whether users feel more in control of their time and experience less guilt.

6. Long-Term User Retention

Evaluate whether users continue using the platform over extended periods without quitting due to burnout or excessive usage.

7. Dashboard Engagement

Measure how often users check their usage statistics and whether awareness leads to behavioral change.

Conclusion (Short Summary):

This case study examined the problem of excessive usage of Reels and its negative impact on productivity, sleep, and overall well-being. Through user observation and survey research, key issues such as prolonged screen time, difficulty stopping, habit formation, and feelings of guilt were identified.

To address these challenges, a set of addiction-control features including Smart Time Limit, Focus Mode, Break Reminders, Auto-Lock, Sleep Protection Mode, and Usage Dashboard was proposed. These features aim to help users manage their time effectively while maintaining the entertainment value of the platform.

Implementing such tools can benefit both users and Meta Platforms by promoting responsible usage, improving brand trust, and ensuring long-term user retention. The proposed success metrics provide a clear framework for evaluating the effectiveness of these solutions.

Overall, the study demonstrates that integrating digital well-being features into Instagram Reels can create a healthier user experience while sustaining business value.

